

Swarnil

An editorial Ghost theme for creators who publish in more than one shape — writing, video and notes — held together by a call-sheet grid and a single signal colour.

VERSION 1.0.0 · GHOST 6.0+ · [HTTPS://IMSWARNIL.GITHUB.IO](https://imswarnil.github.io)

GETTING STARTED · 01

Install

Upload the zip, and the optional routing file. Two steps, both under a minute.

Download `swarnil.zip`, then in Ghost admin:

Settings → Design → Change theme → Upload theme, and select the zip.

That is the entire installation. The theme bundles everything it needs — there is nothing to install, compile or configure first.

Requirements

- Ghost **6.0 or later**. The theme declares this in `package.json`, and Ghost refuses the upload on an older version rather than half-working.
 - No plugins, no build step, no external services.
-

Optional: routing

The theme ships a `routes.yaml` that adds three URLs: `/blog/`, which lists every post, and `/home/sidebar/` and `/home/full/`, which show the homepage with its sidebar forced on and off. Ghost keeps routing separate from themes, so this is a second, deliberate step:

Settings → Labs → Routes → Upload routes file

Everything else works without it. The homepage, all post layouts, tags and author pages need no routing configuration at all — Ghost picks up `home.hbs` for `/` on its own.

The two `/home/` routes exist so both list layouts can be linked side by side. They are safe to delete once you have chosen one.

Before you upload `routes.yaml`, download your current one from the same screen. Routing is site-wide, and uploading a new file replaces whatever you had.

First run

Fifteen minutes from a fresh install to a site that looks like yours.

Fifteen minutes, in this order. Each step is visible on the site immediately.

1. Brand

Settings → Design → Brand

- **Accent colour** — the theme uses exactly one, and rations it: it marks what is live, new, or under the cursor. Pick something that survives on both white and near-black. The theme's own default is a vermilion, `#f04e2e`.
 - **Publication icon** — becomes the favicon.
 - **Logo** — optional. Without one the theme sets your site title in the display face beside a small accent dot, which is a designed state rather than a fallback. Try it before uploading anything.
-

2. Navigation

Settings → Navigation

Primary navigation appears in the header and the mobile drawer. Secondary appears in the footer. Four or five primary items is the practical limit before the header starts competing with your logo.

3. Theme settings

Settings → Design → Site-wide / Homepage / Post

Sixteen settings, all documented in the [settings reference](#). The four worth setting deliberately on day one:

- **Homepage layout** — Call Sheet, Stacked or Grid
- **Homepage lead** — what fills the large slot at the top

- **Post layout** — the default for every post
 - **Typeface pairing** — the display face for headlines
-

4. Feature images

The theme frames every feature image with a viewfinder bracket and crops it to the ratio you choose in **Post** → **Feature image ratio**. 16:9 is the default.

A post without a feature image is fine — the layouts are built for it. In lists the media slot either fills with a hairline hatch or steps out of the way, depending on the layout, so a page of image-less posts still looks deliberate.

5. Members

If you have memberships on, the theme shows a Subscribe button in the header and a newsletter band on the homepage. If you do not, neither appears — there is no setting to turn off, and nothing to hide.

Settings

All sixteen settings, what each one changes, and which four to set on day one.

Every setting is in **Settings → Design**, split into three groups. None of them requires touching code, which is the rule the theme is built to: if you would reasonably want to change it, it is here.

Site-wide

SETTING	OPTIONS	WHAT IT DOES
Colour scheme	System · Light · Dark	What a first-time visitor sees. They can override it with the header toggle, and their choice is remembered.
Typeface pairing	Grotesk & Sans · Serif & Sans · Mono & Sans	The display face used for headlines. Body text never changes.
Header style	Rule · Plate · Over Media	Rule is a hairline underneath. Plate is a filled bar that lifts on scroll. Over Media sits transparently on a feature image and becomes a plate once you scroll past it.
Sidebar on lists	on / off	A second column beside the homepage and archives, with topics, recent posts and the newsletter.
Footer note	text	A short line above the footer navigation. Blank hides it.

Homepage

SETTING	OPTIONS	WHAT IT DOES
Hero CTA label	text	The button in the hero. Blank hides it.
Hero CTA URL	text	Where that button goes. <code>#latest</code> jumps to the post list below.
Show hero signup	on / off	The email form in the hero. Only appears if memberships are on.
Homepage layout	Call Sheet · Stacked · Grid	Call Sheet is a numbered index with hairline rules. Stacked is one full-width card per row. Grid is three across.

Post

SETTING	OPTIONS	WHAT IT DOES
Post layout	Standard · Wide · Immersive	The default for every post. Individual posts override it — see post layouts .
Feature image ratio	auto · 16/9 · 3/2 · 4/3 · 1/1 · 21/9	The crop applied to feature images. <code>auto</code> keeps each image's own shape.
Show reading time	on / off	The estimate in the byline.
Show table of contents	on / off	Built from the headings in each post. Posts with fewer than three headings never show one — a two-item contents list is noise.
Show author card	on / off	The author block beneath a post.
Show read next	on / off	Related posts beneath a post, drawn from the primary tag.

A note on renaming. If you fork the theme and rename a setting's options, rename them everywhere. Ghost compares the stored string exactly, so a site that already chose the old value will silently match nothing.

Layouts

Four post layouts and three homepage shapes, chosen without touching code.

Four layouts. One is the site-wide default; the other three are chosen per post.

Post layouts

Setting the default

Settings → **Design** → **Post** → **Post layout** applies to every post that has not been given its own template.

Overriding one post

Open the post, then in the settings sidebar (the cog, top right) find **Template**. The dropdown lists:

- **Default** — whatever the site-wide setting says
- **Wide** — a broader reading column and a 21:9 feature image, for posts carried by pictures
- **Immersive** — the title set over a full-height feature image
- **Video** — a player-first layout with a chapter list beside the writing

The choice is saved with the post and survives renaming its slug.

Immersive without a feature image renders exactly like Standard. That is deliberate: a title floating on an empty grey block looks broken rather than dramatic. Add an image and the layout appears.

The Video layout

A post on the Video template shows its feature image as a poster at the top, then the writing beside a chapter panel.

Chapters are ordinary list items in the post body that begin with a timestamp:

- 00:00 Introduction
- 01:24 Setting up the shot
- 04:50 The edit

The theme lifts them into the panel. Written as a plain list they still make sense in your RSS feed, in an email newsletter, and for anyone with JavaScript off — nothing about the post depends on the theme to be readable.

Marking a post as video anywhere else on the site — so its card gets a play badge — is done with the internal tag `#video`. Internal tags start with a `#` and are never shown to readers. Add it in the post's tag field alongside your normal tags.

Homepage shapes

Settings → Design → Homepage → Homepage layout

- **Call Sheet** — a numbered index with hairline rules and small media strips. The theme's own voice, and the best choice for a publication that writes more than it shoots.
- **Stacked** — one full-width card per row, media above the words. Good when you have few posts and a grid would look sparse.
- **Grid** — three cards across. The familiar magazine shape.

Shelves

Homepage shelf tags adds a horizontally scrolling row for each tag slug you name. `video,notes` gives two shelves, above the main feed, each linking through to its tag archive.

Use the slug, not the name — `how-to`, not `How To`. Find it in **Tags → (your tag) → Tag slug**. No spaces anywhere in the list.

The header module

Settings → Design → Site-wide → Header style

The header and the hero are one setting, not two, because on two of the five styles they are physically the same object: a transparent bar only works when there is something behind it, and the something is the hero.

STYLE	HEADER	HERO
Rule	a hairline underneath	title, description, actions — centred
Plate	a floating rounded bar, inset from the edges	the same centred hero
Split	a hairline underneath	words left, your publication cover right
Cover	transparent, over the image	the cover image behind the whole band
Broadcast	transparent, over the video	a looping video, with scanlines over it

Everything in the hero comes from things you have already filled in — your publication logo, title, description, cover image and social accounts. The only theme settings are the call to action and, for Broadcast, the video.

Each style degrades rather than breaking. Cover with no publication cover image, and Broadcast with no video URL, both render as the plain centred hero. A brand-new Ghost has neither, so that is what you see before you have uploaded anything.

Cover and Broadcast are only transparent on the homepage, where the media actually is. On a post or an archive they fall back to Rule — a transparent header over a white page is an invisible header.

The Broadcast video

Settings → Design → Site-wide → Hero video URL takes either:

- a YouTube link, in any of its shapes — `youtube.com/watch?v=...`, `youtu.be/...`, `/embed/...` or `/shorts/...`
- a direct file, `https://.../clip.mp4` or `.webm`

The theme works out which it is; you do not have to find a video ID.

It is always muted, always looping, and has no controls — it is a background, not a player. Three things it deliberately will not do:

- **play for anyone who has asked for reduced motion.** The video is never even requested in that case.
- **play sound.** Ever.

- **keep playing off screen.** It loads when the hero comes into view and stops when it leaves, so scrolling down your homepage does not leave a video running behind the rest of the page.

Your publication cover shows underneath as the poster, so the hero looks finished while the video loads — or if it never loads at all.

The sidebar

Settings → Design → Site-wide → Sidebar on lists adds a second column beside the homepage and every archive, holding four widgets: a short about line, your most-used topics, recent posts, and the newsletter form.

Each widget removes itself when it has nothing to show, so a new site does not get a column of empty boxes. On a phone the sidebar moves below the feed rather than disappearing — hiding it would mean the topics and the newsletter simply do not exist where most people read.

If you have uploaded the theme's `routes.yaml`, you can see both versions without changing the setting:

- `/home/sidebar/` — the homepage with the sidebar
- `/home/full/` — the homepage at full width

Navigation dropdowns

Ghost's navigation is a flat list. The theme turns it into one level of dropdown using a convention: **an item whose label starts with `-` becomes a child of the item above it.**

In **Settings → Navigation**, this:

LABEL	URL
Preview	/preview/
Home	/
– With sidebar	/home/sidebar/
– Without sidebar	/home/full/
About	/about/
Blog	/blog/
Contact	/contact/

gives a header of five items, where Home carries a dropdown holding the two homepage layouts. The `–` is a marker only; it never appears on the page.

The parent stays a real link, so Home still goes to `/`. The panel opens on hover and on keyboard focus, and needs no JavaScript.

In the mobile drawer and the footer there is no panel to open: children are indented under their parent and always visible. A dropdown inside a drawer is a menu inside a menu.

One level only. A label like `– – Deeper` will be treated as an ordinary child, not as a grandchild.

The demo content

Import the demo site and start from the same place the preview does.

The demo site is real content, and you can have the same starting point.

Do this on a fresh Ghost install, not on your live site. Importing adds posts, pages, tags and an author. It does not delete anything, but untangling it afterwards is tedious.

1. Download `demo/content.json` from the theme package.
2. In Ghost admin: **Settings → Import/Export → Import content.**
3. Select the file.

You get twelve posts, three pages — About, Preview and Contact — and the tags they use.

Feature images

The import contains no images. A Ghost import file can only reference URLs, and a portable one cannot assume where it will be imported.

Add your own, or use the cover art in `demo/covers/` — twelve flat SVGs drawn in the theme's palette. Upload one per post through the editor's feature image field.

Settings the demo uses

SETTING	VALUE
Homepage layout	Call Sheet
Homepage lead	Featured Post
Homepage shelf tags	<code>handlebars, layouts</code>
Post layout	Standard
Header style	Rule
Typeface pairing	Grotesk & Sans
Accent colour	<code>#f04e2e</code>

Navigation, in **Settings → Navigation** — note the `-` prefixes, which make the two indented items into a dropdown under Home:

LABEL	URL
<code>Preview</code>	<code>/preview/</code>
<code>Home</code>	<code>/</code>
<code>- With sidebar</code>	<code>/home/sidebar/</code>
<code>- Without sidebar</code>	<code>/home/full/</code>
<code>About</code>	<code>/about/</code>
<code>Blog</code>	<code>/blog/</code>
<code>Contact</code>	<code>/contact/</code>

Secondary navigation: a few tag archives and the author page.

The `/blog/`, `/home/sidebar/` and `/home/full/` URLs need the theme's `routes.yaml` uploaded under **Settings → Labs → Routes**.

The "Every layout" page

The demo includes a page that links to a live example of every template the theme ships. It is worth keeping while you are deciding which layouts you want — it is faster than switching settings back and forth.

Customising

Change fonts, widths and corners from code injection — no theme edits, no lost work on update.

Everything below is optional. The theme is designed to be finished as shipped.

Without touching files

Settings → Code injection → Site header takes CSS that loads after the theme's own. This is the supported way to change things, and it survives theme updates — edits to the theme files do not.

The theme's whole appearance is driven by custom properties. Override them and every component follows, in both colour schemes:

```
<style>
  :root {
    --t-w-prose: 46rem;          /* wider reading column          */
    --t-radius-card: 0.25rem;    /* squarer corners              */
    --t-header-h: 5rem;         /* taller header                */
    --t-bracket-size: 0;        /* turn the viewfinder off      */
  }
</style>
```

Change the accent through **Settings → Design → Brand** rather than in CSS — the theme derives its hover and focus tints from it, so setting it there keeps all the states in step.

A custom font

```
<link rel="preconnect" href="https://fonts.googleapis.com">
<link href="https://fonts.googleapis.com/css2?family=Fraunces:wght@400;700&display=swa
<style>
  :root { --t-font-display: 'Fraunces', Georgia, serif; }
</style>
```


Set `--t-font-display` for headlines, `--t-font-body` for body text, and `--t-font-slate` for the monospaced metadata. Changing all three at once is usually a mistake — the theme's rhythm depends on the three being distinct.

Editing the theme

If you do edit the files, the source lives in `assets/css/` and is compiled to `assets/built/index.css`. Editing the built file directly works until the next rebuild overwrites it.

```
npm install
npm run dev      # watch
npm run test     # gscan, before uploading anything
```

One rule matters more than the rest: **component CSS reads `--t-*` tokens only**. Those are defined in `assets/css/01-contract/tokens.css` and are the reason light and dark, and the typeface settings, work at all. Reaching past them to a raw colour is what makes a customised copy stop responding to its own settings.

Troubleshooting

The eight things that actually go wrong, and what each one means.

The homepage is a plain list, not the layout I chose

The homepage sections come from `home.hbs`, which Ghost uses automatically. If you are seeing a plain paginated list, a `routes.yaml` on your site is pointing `/` somewhere else. Check **Settings → Labs → Routes**.

A shelf is empty or missing

Homepage shelf tags takes tag *slugs*, comma-separated, with no spaces. `video, notes` fails because of the space; `video,notes` works. Find the slug under **Tags → (your tag) → Tag slug**.

A shelf also needs published posts carrying that tag.

A navigation dropdown does not open

Children are marked with a leading `–` and a space `– With sidebar`, not `–With sidebar`. Without the space the item is treated as an ordinary top-level link, and the parent gets no chevron.

Only one level is supported.

/blog/ or /home/sidebar/ gives a 404

Those URLs come from the theme's `routes.yaml`, which Ghost does not install with a theme. Upload it under **Settings → Labs → Routes**.

The table of contents does not appear

It needs at least three `##` or `###` headings in the post. Below that the theme removes it, because a two-item contents list is noise. Check the setting is on under **Settings → Design → Post**.

My accent colour looks wrong in dark mode

The theme derives hover and focus tints from your accent, lightening them in dark mode and darkening them in light. Very dark accents have little room to darken further. If the hover state is invisible, pick a mid-tone accent — one that works as text on white *and* as a fill on near-black.

The colour scheme flashes on load

It should not: the theme resolves the scheme in a small inline script before the page paints. If you see a flash, something in **Code injection → Site header** is loading a large blocking stylesheet ahead of it. Move it to the footer, or load it asynchronously.

Posts disappeared after uploading routes.yaml

Almost always a `filter` on the root collection. Every post belongs to exactly one collection, and its URL comes from that collection — so a post excluded by a filter, with no other collection to catch it, has no URL at all. It is still in admin, still marked published, and unreachable.

Either remove the filter or add a second, unfiltered collection beneath it.

An update did not change anything

Ghost caches theme assets aggressively. After uploading a new version, hard refresh (**Cmd/Ctrl + Shift + R**). If you are behind a CDN, purge its cache too.

Something else

Email the address in `package.json` . Include your Ghost version, the theme version from **Settings → Design**, and a link to the page that is wrong.